



Photographs by BRIAN VAN DER BRUG Los Angeles Times

WORKERS for a roofing company assemble to shovel snow off a building early this month in Mammoth Lakes, Calif.

A MAMMOTH NEED FOR IMMIGRANT WORKERS

Resort town runs on labor of many who lack documentation. Some say a walkout would hammer home the reality of Trump’s deportation plan.

By Jack Dolan | REPORTING FROM MAMMOTH LAKES, CALIF.

If all the service workers born in Mexico stayed home from their jobs for just one day in this thriving resort town perched high in California’s Sierra Nevada, the humming tourist economy would probably face-plant harder than a first-time skier on an icy expert slope.

Most of the restaurants would have no staff, residents say. Hotels and Airbnbs would suffer the same fate. Construction projects across this posh skiing destination would come to a grinding halt.

“I think that would be like one of those zombie movies,” said Jose Diaz, 33, from Sinaloa, a supervisor at the Stove, a cozy breakfast spot in the heart of town.

Like so many others who have



MIGRANTS came to the resort town after hearing that it was a good place to earn a steady paycheck.

made their way here from small towns in Mexico, Diaz didn’t come for the skiing. He had heard through the grapevine that Mammoth was a good place to earn a steady paycheck.

That was 14 years ago. Now, Diaz and his wife — she’s from Guadalajara, and they met working at a Mammoth restaurant — are both here legally, he said. They have two kids born in the U.S. and recently bought a condo in town.

But, like almost everyone else in this alpine community of about 7,000 people, they have friends and family who would be vulnerable if President-elect Donald Trump’s pronouncements about deporting mil-

[See Mammoth, A9]

To end wildfire cycle, a look to nature

Native species of oak could be a solution to dangerous feedback loop in the Malibu area, experts say.

By Noah Haggerty

A red glow illuminated the valley behind the Brunel family’s Malibu home around 11 p.m. Monday. The fierce Santa Ana winds blowing dry desert air over the mountains and out to sea had already triggered public safety power shutoffs.

The family, whose previous home was destroyed by the 2018 Woolsey fire, knew it was a bad sign. They started packing and turned on their water sprinklers.

By 1 a.m. they were driving to Pepperdine University as flames raced along Malibu Canyon and up toward their home. Pepperdine buzzed with life as some students evacuated and others hunkered down in the school’s library.

The fire quickly blew through the Brunels’ neighborhood and reached campus.

Two hours later, it had all passed.

Fires have always been part of life in the Santa Monica Mountains, but in recent decades, they’ve exploded in frequency and fe-

[See Wildfires, A7]

Let GOP into state Latino caucus?

Amid a Latino shift toward Trump, the legislative group mulls inviting Republicans.

GUSTAVO ARELLANO

Over the phone, Lena Gonzalez’s voice had the patient but proud tone of a lawyer charged with defending the damned.

Her metaphorical client: The California Latino Legislative Caucus, which the Long Beach-area state senator heads.

At 38 members strong, it’s one of the largest groups of its kind in the United States and has long served as the tip of California’s progressive spear. Members helped transform the state within a generation from a place that birthed the notorious anti-immigrant Proposition 187 into one where people without proper documentation can apply for driver’s licenses, health insurance, get in-state college tuition and more.

[See Arellano, A8]



Photo illustration by ALLISON HONG Los Angeles Times; photos from Los Angeles County Sheriff’s Department, New York Public Library

COLUMN ONE

An 836-pound ‘cursed’ emerald cut a path of havoc in the Americas

By Clara Harter

It was an ordinary day at his Los Angeles law office when John Nadolenco opened a letter from Brazil enlisting his help in a mission to retrieve a stolen, and quite possibly cursed, 836-pound emerald.

The year was 2014, the heyday of the Nigerian prince email scam, and the up-and-coming attorney was no fool.

“I immediately thought it was just completely fake, a total hoax,” he said. “I was like, ‘I’m not falling for this one. I’m smarter than this.’”

He tossed the letter in the trash.

[See Emerald, A18]

Amid controversy, Times owner discusses the future

Patrick Soon-Shiong had become accustomed to making the news.

He was the doctor and medical technology innovator who built a fortune, the striving South African immigrant who bought a piece of the Lakers and the L.A. billionaire who brought the Los Angeles Times back under local control when he purchased it in 2018.

But none of that created

Patrick Soon-Shiong explains ‘bias meter’ and his vision to build readership

By James Rainey

the public tempest like the one that has surrounded Soon-Shiong’s recent actions: First when he blocked the Times editorial board, which he oversees, from endorsing Vice President Kamala Harris for president. Then he suggested the newspaper had become an “echo chamber” for the political left. And, this month, he announced The Times would

[See Soon-Shiong, A10]

S. Korean leader Yoon impeached

A dozen lawmakers in president’s party turn against him over martial law. A snap election could follow. **WORLD, A3**

Police struggle on MacArthur Park

Officers speak with columnist Steve Lopez about the challenges of monitoring the troubled area. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

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JULIA SCHIMAUTZ For The Times

Critics’ picks from a wild year

“Dune: Part Two,” Chappell Roan, L.A. Phil, Ed Ruscha, “Shogun” and more. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

Weather

Mostly sunny. L.A. Basin: 67/49. **B8**

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